

Alice's Adventures in Wonderland — Chapter VII

There was a table set out under a tree in front of the house, and the March Hare and the Hatter were having tea at it: a Dormouse was sitting between them, fast asleep, and the other two were using it as a cushion, resting their elbows on it, and talking over its head. 'Very uncomfortable for the Dormouse,' thought Alice, 'only, as it's asleep, I suppose it doesn't mind.'

The table was a large one, but the three were all crowded together at one corner of it: 'No room! No room!' they cried out when they saw Alice coming. 'There's plenty of room!' said Alice indignantly, and she sat down in a large arm-chair at one end of the table.

'Have some wine,' the March Hare said in an encouraging tone. Alice looked all round the table, but there was nothing on it but tea. 'I don't see any wine,' she remarked. 'There isn't any,' said the March Hare. 'Then it wasn't very civil of you to offer it,' said Alice angrily.

'It wasn't very civil of you to sit down without being invited,' said the March Hare. 'I didn't know it was your table,' said Alice; 'it's laid for a great many more than three.' 'Your hair wants cutting,' said the Hatter. He had been looking at Alice for some time with great curiosity, and this was his first speech.

'You should learn not to make personal remarks,' Alice said with some severity; 'it's very rude.' The Hatter opened his eyes very wide on hearing this; but all he said was 'Why is a raven like a writing-desk?' 'Come, we shall have some fun now,' thought Alice.

'I'm glad they've begun asking riddles — I believe I can guess that,' she added aloud. 'Do you mean that you think you can find out the answer to it?' said the March Hare. 'Exactly so,' said Alice. 'Then you should say what you mean,' the March Hare went on. 'I do,' Alice hastily replied; 'at least — at least I mean what I say — that's the same thing, you know.' 'Not the same thing a bit!' said the Hatter. 'You might just as well say that "I see what I eat" is the same thing as "I eat what I see"!'.

'It is the same thing with you,' said the Hatter, and here the conversation dropped, and the party sat silent for a minute, while Alice thought over all she could remember about ravens and writing-desks, which wasn't much. The Hatter was the first to break the silence. 'What day of the month is it?' he said, turning to Alice: he had taken his watch out of his pocket, and was looking at it uneasily, as well he might. 'The fourth,' said Alice.

'Two days wrong!' sighed the Hatter. 'I told you butter wouldn't suit the works,' he added looking angrily at the March Hare. 'It was the best butter,' the March Hare meekly replied. 'Yes, but some crumbs must have got in as well,' the Hatter grumbled: 'you shouldn't have put it in with the bread-knife.' The March Hare took the watch and looked at it gloomily: then he dipped it into his cup of tea, and looked at it again: but he could think of nothing better to say than his first remark, 'It was the best butter, you know.'

'Take some more tea,' the March Hare said to Alice, very earnestly. 'I've had nothing yet,' Alice replied in an offended tone, 'so I can't take more.' 'You mean you can't take less,' said the Hatter: 'it's very easy to take more than nothing.' 'Nobody asked your opinion,' said Alice. 'That's not manners,' said the Hatter. 'Manners!' cried the old Queen. 'Don't be impertinent,' said the Queen, 'and don't look at me like that!' She said this as she took a fan from her pocket.

Alice heard the Queen say 'Off with her head!' and trembled a little, but she knew that the rulers of Wonderland seldom executed anybody, so she went on, without showing any fear. 'Have you guessed the riddle yet?' the Hatter said, turning to Alice again. 'No, I give it up,' Alice replied. 'What's the answer?' 'I haven't the slightest idea,' said the Hatter. 'Nor I,' said the March Hare. Alice sighed wearily. 'I think you might do something better with the time,' she said, 'than waste it asking riddles with no answers.'

The Hatter took his watch out of his pocket again, and looked uneasily at it, and then hurried on. 'What a beautiful brooch you've got, Dormouse!' Alice remarked. 'Oh, isn't it?' said the March Hare. 'It was a present from the White Rabbit.' 'No, it wasn't,' said the Dormouse sulkily. 'I found it myself.' But the Hatter and the March Hare had already fled, and the Dormouse had crept away, so Alice sat down on the bank, and began to think.

She thought, very seriously, 'What shall I do with this little thing?' And she opened her hand, and looked at the tiny golden key. 'It must be the key to the garden! It must be!' And she hurried back to the little house, wondering whether she could find the right lock. She tried the smallest door, but the key would not turn in it. So she sat down again, and felt very gloomy, and began to cry.

'You ought to be ashamed of yourself,' said Alice, 'a great girl like that,' she added in a more encouraging tone, 'to go on crying in this way over a trifle!' But she went on crying all the same, while the tears rolled down her cheeks. Presently there came a curious feeling of faintness, and she fancied that her feet were moving of their own accord, and that she was shrinking. Looking down, she saw to her great surprise that she was only ten inches high.

'So I am now,' said Alice to herself, in a melancholy tone, 'and I don't know what has become of me.' She was still looking at the key, when a great crash shook the house from top to bottom. The next moment the White Rabbit came rushing in, with a pair of white kid gloves in one hand and a large fan in the other. 'Oh my dear, oh my dear!' cried Alice, in great distress. 'I do hope they haven't killed poor Bill!'

'Oh! Bill's in danger again,' said the White Rabbit. 'Where did you drop from?' said Alice, who had recovered from her fright. 'Down a chimney,' said the White Rabbit. 'And the fan?' said Alice, who had caught the fan and gloves. 'My fan!' the White Rabbit cried out, and he hurried on, with the Dormouse following. Alice stood and watched them, till they were out of sight, and then she picked up the key and walked softly to the little door.

'Poor little thing!' said Alice, in a coaxing tone, and she pushed the key into the lock, and was delighted to find it turn. She tumbled head over heels into the garden, and the first thing she saw was a great rose-tree, covered with white roses. Three gardeners were busily painting them red. Alice walked up to them, and said, very politely, 'Excuse me, but why are you painting them so?'

'Why, that's because the Queen has ordered them to be painted red,' said one of the gardeners, in a frightened tone. 'The Queen! She'll be terribly angry if she finds out,' said another. 'She's awfully cross, you know,' said the third. Alice observed that they were all three dreadfully afraid of the Queen, and she thought to herself, 'I should like to see her, if I could.' 'You'd better not,' said the gardener, who had been reading her thoughts in some strange manner.

Just at this moment, five or six of the soldiers came running in, and the Queen flew at them in a furious passion. 'What are you doing here?' she shouted. 'We were planting a tree,' said one of the soldiers, in great confusion. 'Oh, you silly fellow!' said the Queen, tossing her head impatiently. 'Here, Bill! catch hold of this brat's head, and off with it!' But Alice caught the baby up in her arms, and it stopped crying directly. 'A pickle!' said the Queen, in a louder tone than before.

Alice was rather doubtful whether she ought not to lie down on her face like the three gardeners, but she could not remember ever having heard of such a rule at all. 'Besides, what would be the use of a procession,' thought she, 'if everybody had to lie down?' So she stood still, looking at the procession as it passed. When it had gone by, she walked on, and found that the Queen was not very far behind. She did not like the look of the thing at all, but she thought there was no time to be lost, as she was already beginning to shrink again.

'What's the matter?' said Alice to herself, as she ran. 'I haven't been beaten yet. I am not going to be, if I can help it.' 'Oh, there goes his head!' she heard the King say, in a voice of despair. 'Run! Run!' cried the Gryphon, with great eagerness. 'Off with his head!' was heard from every side, and Alice lost no time in darting across the lawn to rejoin the procession. She was much relieved to find that she had gained a few yards.

Alice was very glad to find herself still in the garden, where she had been all the time, though she knew that she had only been there a few minutes. 'And as for the little golden key,' said Alice, 'I only wish I could shut my eyes and open them again, and find myself in another place. I don't much care where,' said Alice, 'so long as I get somewhere.' However, she was still peering about anxiously among the trees, when the White Rabbit came running up to her, very much out of breath.

'The Queen! The Queen!' shouted the White Rabbit, as he came pelting up to her. Alice felt a sudden dread, and she stood still, looking at the Rabbit, who was trembling with anxiety. 'Where is the Queen?' said Alice. 'She's coming, I tell you!' cried the White Rabbit, in a low voice. 'You must run away, Alice, or you'll be beheaded.' 'Don't be silly,' said Alice. 'The Queen won't hear of your cutting off anybody's head. Just look at me!' And she held up her hand to shield her eyes from the sunlight.

There was a long silence after this, broken by Alice saying, 'Well, I never heard of such a thing before!' The Dormouse shook its head. 'You might have guessed,' it said. 'All that time we were playing with a Dormouse,' said Alice. 'I declare it's too bad, all this fuss with the Dormouse!' 'It isn't,' said Alice, in a coaxing tone. 'I'm sure I don't want to be a footman in a procession. I'd much rather be a madam in a house, wouldn't you?' said Alice to herself, for she was beginning to feel a little tired of sitting on the bank by herself.

The Hatter was the first to break the silence. 'What day of the month is it?' he said, turning to Alice: he had taken his watch out of his pocket, and was looking at it uneasily, as well he might. 'The fourth,' said Alice. 'Ah, that's a long time ago,' said the Hatter. 'It must have been a very expensive one,' said Alice thoughtfully, 'if it's so very much out of repair.' The Hatter sighed deeply, and began to mourn over it as if it had been a real one that had been lost. 'I'm a poor man,' he said.

'I'm afraid you've offended it,' said Alice. 'It looked at me so sternly when I came near it,' she added. 'But it doesn't matter,' she said to herself, 'I don't care for the Dormouse. I'm tired of this game. Let us sit down and have some tea.' The Hatter looked surprised. 'Have some what?' he said. 'Tea,' said Alice, with a little timidity. 'It's always tea-time.' The Hatter took out his watch and looked at it. 'Time for tea!' he said. 'It's always tea-time.'

'Why, is it always tea-time?' said Alice. 'Yes, that's why,' said the Hatter. 'It's always tea-time, and there's no time to wash the things between whiles.' 'Then you keep moving round, I suppose?' said Alice. 'Exactly so,' said the Hatter: 'as the things get used up, the things get used up, you know.' 'But what happens when you come to the beginning again?' Alice ventured to ask. 'Suppose we change the subject,' the March Hare interrupted, yawning. 'I'm getting tired of this. I vote the young lady tells us a story.'

And so it was indeed: she was now only ten inches high, and her face brightened up at the thought that she was now the right size for going through the little door into that beautiful garden. However, she waited for a few minutes to see if she was going to shrink any further: she felt a little nervous about this; 'for it might end, you know,' said Alice to herself, 'in my going out altogether, like a candle. I wonder what I should be like then?' And she tried to fancy what the flame of a candle is like after the candle is blown out, for she could not remember ever having seen such a thing.

However, this was a great wonder to Alice, and she went on thinking about it for some time. 'After such a fall as this, I shall think nothing of tumbling down stairs. How brave they'll all think me at home! Why, I wouldn't say anything about it, even if I fell over the top of the house!' (Which was very likely true.) Down, down, down. Would the fall never come to an end! 'I wonder how many miles I've fallen by this time?' she said aloud. 'I must be getting somewhere near the bottom of the earth.'